

searched. Only when nothing is found on them are they taken to a hospital.

The incident could easily belong to those vast tracts of national lawlessness and deprivation—Bihar and Uttar Pradesh. It actually took place one sunny Sunday afternoon in Edappal, in Kerala's Malappuram district. Of the women attacked, Jyothi, 40, was seven months pregnant, and her daughter Kavitha was 16. Edappal's violence stopped Kerala cold. The state's television stations called it "the Bihar Model" of justice and state Home Minister Koderi Balakrishnan, thundered, "Such things should not happen in Kerala. What is the difference between Kerala and Bihar then?"

It is already too late for rhetoric in

fire to shops and 20 vehicles parked on the side of the road after a runaway truck mowed down four members of a Shab-e-Barat procession. The mob had an hour to vandalise its surroundings before the police stepped in.

In Mumbai, around the same time, a group of 100 broke into a Thane man's home and beat him up for allegedly molesting his maid.

In Chennai, the city's normally even-tempered train commuters, torched a compartment due to a peak hour delay. Among those arrested were women office-goers.

In Jaipur's SMS Hospital, the biggest in the state, resident doctors have gone on strike following half a dozen cases of being manhandled by



Edappal, Kerala HELL'S OWN PLAYGROUND

"The incident shows how anti-women Kerala males are."

K. AJITHA, FORMER NAXALITE LEADER

On October 7 two women, were thrashed by a mob in Edappal on charges of theft. After 45 minutes, the women were rescued by a police team and found blameless. Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan has ordered a police inquiry. The state Human Rights Commission has suo moto filed a case.

what is turning out to be India's autumn of angst. As the country celebrated 60 years of Independence and the stock exchange index ascended with no fear of vertigo, all across the country, the ordinary citizen became angrier and angrier. This rage spilt over into arson and violence, instant justice and murder. It is as if small groups of disenchanted Indians decided to take the law into their own hands and so, are waging a guerrilla war against the police, the judiciary and their polity.

In late August, in Agra, a crowd set

patients. Angry groups in Rajasthan now routinely break into government offices to blacken the faces of those who don't respond to civic complaints.

'Ration riots' have broken out in six southern districts of West Bengal after year-long shortages in ration shops. The mob has begun ransacking the shops and residences of ration dealers, four of whom have committed suicide.

Delhi, the national capital of road rage, has witnessed a 50 per cent increase in 'riot' cases, the clause under which the police book those accused of causing public disorder. From 57 cases

RISING RAGE

Oct 7, 2007 DELHI: Angry locals blocked the highway, damaged three buses, pelted stones at the police and attempted to burn a bus that ran into around 20 people at an unauthorised bus stop in Delhi, killing seven and leaving 10 others injured.

Oct 1, 2007 HYDERABAD: Alleging that the principal of a convent school was misbehaving with girl students and forcing a school teacher to marry him, about 150 people ransacked the school and burnt the furniture.

Sept 22, 2007 DELHI: Two police posts were set on fire by a mob around Jamia Milia Islamia University. About 40 people, including policemen, were injured. In the course of an encroachment removal drive the Koran was reportedly dropped by a policeman, leading to violence.

Nov 30, 2006 MUMBAI: Angered by the desecration of B.R. Ambedkar's statue in Kanpur, Dalits in several parts of Maharashtra went on a rampage setting three trains on fire, damaging over 100 buses and clashing with the police in violent protests that left four dead and over 60 injured. Curfew was imposed in many areas.

July 25, 2005 GURGAON: A protest by workers of Honda Motorcycle and Scooter India seeking higher wages and re-employment of suspended employees snowballed into a major confrontation in Gurgaon. Trouble started after the protesters attacked the police with stones and sticks near the ITI on the Mehrauli-Gurgaon road and torched police vehicles. Later, the police surrounded the workers and thrashed them, leaving many with broken limbs.

Aug 13, 2004 NAGPUR: A criminal, Bharat alias Akku Yadav, involved in over two dozen cases of murder, extortion, dacoity, robbery, theft, rioting and molestation was brought to a court in Nagpur when a mob comprising mostly women stormed the courtroom and lynched him. The court was not in session and the escorting constables had no option but to be mute witnesses to the bizarre happening.

"These incidents reflect a general degradation in society and impatience with the slow pace of the criminal justice system."

DULAL CHANDRA DEY, IGR, RAPID ACTION FORCE